NOTE As I mentioned previously, a web API project is a standard ASP.NET Core project, which uses the MVC framework and web API controllers.

Some people think of the MVC design pattern as applying only to applications that render their UI directly, like the Razor views you've seen in previous chapters or MVC controllers with Razor views. However, in ASP.NET Core, I feel the MVC pattern applies equally well when building a web API. For web APIs, the *view* part of the MVC pattern involves generating a *machine*-friendly response rather than a *user*-friendly response.

As a parallel to this, you create web API controllers in ASP.NET Core in the same way you create traditional MVC controllers. The only thing that differentiates them from a code perspective is the type of data they return. MVC controllers typically return a `ViewResult`; web API controllers generally return raw .NET objects from their action methods, or an `IActionResult` instance such as `StatusCodeResult`, as you saw in chapter 15.

You can create a new web API project in Visual Studio using the same process you've seen previously in Visual Studio. Choose **File** > **New**, and in the **Create a new project** dialog box, select the **ASP.NET Core Web API** template. Enter your project name in the **Configure your new project** dialog box, and review the **Additional Information** box, shown in figure 20.1, before choosing **Create**. If you're using the command-line interface (CLI), you can create a similar template using `dotnet new webapi`.